

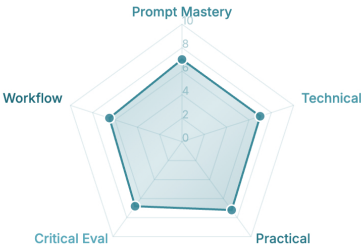


Michael, here's your AI Fluency Score

7.0 **MEDIUM VELOCITY**
Overall Score

↗ Final Rubric Scores

Michael, these scores reflect your demonstrated ability across each competency dimension.



PROMPT MASTERY 7.0 out of 10	TECHNICAL UNDERSTANDING 7.0 out of 10	PRACTICAL APPLICATION 7.2 out of 10
CRITICAL EVALUATION 6.8 out of 10	WORKFLOW DESIGN 6.5 out of 10	

📄 Interview Section Notes

Michael, these are notes from each section of the evaluation. They provide useful context, but your final rubric scores above are the primary signal.

Section 1: Context & Baseline

Summary

Michael is a disciplined, philosophically-trained user who began using Claude in 2024 and quickly built a sophisticated personal knowledge architecture: a GitHub repository as a persistent identity/context layer feeding into Claude Projects organized around specific life domains. He brought pre-existing Zettelkasten habits and formal training in classical philosophy (Aristotelian systems) directly into his AI workflows. He works as an engineering manager with experience leading two multi-regional teams on a billion-dollar enterprise application, and currently does client development work (React Native/Expo EPUB reader) using Claude Code and Codex. He also holds teaching roles where he uses AI for grading (TTS), curriculum design, and formatting tasks. His AI use spans strategic thinking, life planning, writing, and software engineering. He has written on the intersection of Aristotle's philosophical system and LLMs in the context of interpretability. He consistently approaches AI as a thinking partner, bringing his own structured frameworks rather than deferring to the model for structure.

Key Insights

- Transferred analog Zettelkasten organizational habits directly into a GitHub + Claude Projects architecture — shows systems thinking predating AI adoption
- Uses classical philosophical frameworks (scholastic method, Aristotelian reasoning) to structure prompts and surface the 'why' behind specs — unusually meta approach to prompt design
- Engages with AI at both applied and conceptual levels (interpretability writing on Aristotle + LLMs)
- AI use spans a wide band: strategic life thinking, teaching workflows, software engineering, and client development
- Treats AI as a thinking partner augmenting pre-existing frameworks, not as a source of structure

Strengths

- Highly systematic personal knowledge architecture (GitHub context repo + domain-specific Claude Projects)
- Strong philosophical and classical reasoning background that informs prompt design and AI interaction quality
- Broad applied experience across domains: engineering management, teaching, client development
- Early adopter who built sophisticated workflows quickly, suggesting fast learning curve

- Reflective and meta-aware about how and why he uses AI tools

Areas for Improvement

- Has explored but stepped back from more sophisticated agentic workflows (RAG, LangChain, LangGraph) in favor of simpler tool-switching — may represent a ceiling in technical AI orchestration depth
- AI use described as largely ad hoc outside of coding — may indicate less systematic evaluation of AI outputs in non-technical domains

Knowledge Gaps

- Depth of hands-on experience with agentic/multi-step workflows beyond exploration phase
- How critically he evaluates AI outputs vs. accepts them, especially in strategic/life-planning contexts
- Familiarity with AI limitations, failure modes, and calibration of trust across task types

Section 2: Prompt Mastery

Summary

Michael demonstrated a coherent, philosophically grounded prompting philosophy centered on preserving human intellectual agency. His initial prompt showed real craft in style preservation and behavioral constraints (voice matching via attached writing, em dash exclusion), but intentionally omitted audience, hook type, end goal, and outline. He articulated this as a deliberate strategy rather than oversight. His iteration technique — inline annotation with quoted comparisons anchored to audience and end goal — is more precise than most users'. His epub debugging story was the strongest signal: he correctly diagnosed a model stuck in a local optimization loop, reframed the problem structurally by introducing cross-epub comparison, and unblocked the model. This shows genuine understanding of model failure modes, not just trial-and-error retrying.

Key Insights

- Michael's prompting philosophy is deliberately human-in-the-loop at every stage — he designs prompts to generate material to react against, not to automate output
- His iteration technique of inline annotation with comparison is genuinely precise and targets local failures without discarding what works
- The epub debugging story demonstrates real diagnostic ability: he identified the model's failure mode (local optimization loop) and reframed structurally rather than retrying
- His Aristotelian compare-and-contrast framework functions as both a personal organizing metaphor and a practically effective prompting technique
- The line between strategic ambiguity and underspecification is not always clear in his initial prompts — he conflates the two at times

Strengths

- Strong iteration craft — inline annotation with quoted comparisons is a high-precision technique
- Genuine failure mode diagnosis in the epub case — identified structural reframe needed rather than retrying the same approach
- Behavioral constraints in prompts (style matching, em dash exclusion) show awareness of what actually changes model output
- Coherent and self-aware prompting philosophy with a clear rationale for leaving agency with the human

Areas for Improvement

- Initial prompts are systematically underspecified on audience, hook type, end goal, and structure — even when these are known
- The distinction between intentional strategic ambiguity and simply not front-loading context is blurry in practice
- Did not demonstrate writing a fully-formed, constraint-rich prompt unprompted — the gaps were only named after probing

Knowledge Gaps

- Whether his front-loading omissions consistently produce better outcomes or sometimes just create more correction work downstream
- How he handles failure modes beyond the compare-and-contrast reframe — his toolkit may be narrower than his diagnostic ability suggests
- Whether his Aristotelian framing produces structurally different prompts or primarily serves as a post-hoc explanatory metaphor

Section 3: Technical Understanding

Summary

Michael demonstrated strong practical technical understanding grounded in real failure experiences. He identified hallucination as a gap-filling behavior under novel conditions, not random error, and built a sourcing-first workflow to mitigate it. He named three distinct failure categories — temporal/factual errors, value override, and style drift — and has active mitigations for each. His structured solutioning framework (modeled on Aristotelian faculty psychology) shows he thinks about AI workflow at an architectural level, not just prompt-by-prompt. His handling of context window degradation (chat extraction, summarized context handoff) reflects genuine operational sophistication. The main gap is that his explanations of *why* models behave as they do remain

representation. The main gap is that the explanations of why models generate as they do remain somewhat intuitive rather than mechanistic — he has strong pattern recognition but doesn't always articulate the underlying model behavior precisely.

Key Insights

- Hallucination diagnosed as plausibility-filling under novel/underspecified conditions, not random noise
- Sourcing primary texts directly to the model is his core mitigation for citation unreliability
- Identifies context window length as a structural failure mode and has an extraction workflow for it
- Built a prompt architecture modeled on Aristotelian faculty psychology — sensory input, gestalt, building blocks, comparison, judgment
- Recognizes value override (model substituting its opinion for user experience) as a distinct failure mode and handles it conversationally
- Timestamp shortcut added as a practical mitigation for temporal reasoning errors

Strengths

- Failure diagnosis is concrete and specific — he can name what went wrong and why
- Has built real mitigations for each failure mode he's identified, not just awareness
- Treats context window degradation as a structural issue, not a model personality problem
- Process architecture (faculty psychology framework) shows systems-level thinking about AI workflow
- Distinguishes confidence from correctness — knows when to verify regardless of how authoritative the output sounds

Areas for Improvement

- Explanations of model behavior are intuitive and pattern-based rather than mechanistic — e.g. 'more eager to engineer quotations' is a useful heuristic but not a precise account of what's happening
- Limited explicit discussion of when not to use AI at all — his mitigations are mostly about correcting AI rather than replacing it
- Tool/model selection reasoning wasn't surfaced — unclear how he decides between models or approaches

Knowledge Gaps

- Mechanistic understanding of why hallucination occurs (training data distribution, next-token prediction under low-confidence conditions)
- Explicit criteria for when to bypass AI entirely
- Model selection reasoning — what drives choice of tool or approach for a given task

Section 4: Critical Evaluation

Summary

Michael demonstrated a verification process grounded in close reading, quote extraction, primary source checking, and domain expertise. His most concrete example was catching a hallucinated Aquinas quote by recognizing anachronistic writing style — the output read like a modern summary rather than Aquinas's actual technical prose. He has a standing habit of checking sources for citations and uses himself as the benchmark for acceptable output: if it follows formal logic, cites verifiable sources, and feels like something he could have reasonably produced, it clears his bar. He also noted that his upstream prompting philosophy (preserving his own judgment) reduces downstream verification burden. He has tried cross-model comparison but doesn't reach for it often.

Key Insights

- His primary verification mechanism is domain expertise — he caught the Aquinas hallucination because he recognized anachronistic voice, not through a systematic process
- He uses himself as the quality benchmark: output that feels like something he could produce, follows logic, and has verifiable sources is deemed safe
- His upstream prompting philosophy (sourcing-first, preserving his judgment) is doing real work to reduce verification load downstream
- He has a standing rule to check citations, which is a meaningful and repeatable habit
- Cross-model comparison exists in his toolkit but is rarely deployed

Strengths

- Caught a plausible hallucination through stylistic recognition — a sophisticated, expertise-based detection mechanism
- Has a consistent citation-checking habit that applies regardless of how confident the output looks
- Articulates a clear personal benchmark for output acceptability (logic, sourcing, self-resemblance)
- Understands that upstream prompt design reduces downstream verification work

Areas for Improvement

- Verification process is heavily expertise-dependent — in unfamiliar domains the same instincts may not fire
- No described systematic checklist or repeatable framework beyond citation checking
- Self-as-benchmark is a useful heuristic but can create blind spots where his own knowledge has gaps
- Cross-model comparison, a strong verification tool, is underutilized

Knowledge Gaps

- How he verifies output in domains where he lacks deep expertise
- Whether he has a process for catching logical errors versus factual errors specifically
- How he handles stakes calibration — does he verify more rigorously when consequences are higher

Section 5: Workflow Design

Summary

Michael described a recurring workflow for writing Substack articles that integrate Thomist faculty psychology with contemporary AI research. The process begins with substantial pre-model intellectual work — reading, connecting, and internalizing ideas before opening the model. He then uses AI as a Socratic sparring partner, sharing his internal monologue in structured form (what he's doing, what generated the idea, where he sees connections, where he sees gaps) before moving into drafting, iterative feedback, and lightweight editing. He previously experimented with version-control-style prompt systems but shifted to a looser, more conversational approach after empirically finding that AI performs better when given room to fill gaps. He identified his key failure condition: entering the model before ideas are sufficiently baked, which creates a "reeling in a fish" struggle. He also candidly noted that AI serves an emotional and motivational function — providing intellectual validation and structural sponsorship that keeps him writing even when external response is absent.

Key Insights

- Michael's workflow is genuinely integrated and recurring, not occasional experimentation — AI is central to his Substack output
- He has run informal experiments on workflow design (structured vs. Socratic prompting) and drawn evidence-based conclusions
- His 'judgment sits on top' philosophy is a mature instinct but remains largely tacit and difficult to systematize
- He has accurate self-knowledge about his failure condition: under-baked ideas before model entry
- AI serves a motivational and companionship function for him beyond pure productivity — an honest and underappreciated use case

Strengths

- Clear multi-phase workflow with distinct idea-baking, sparring, drafting, and editing stages
- Empirical mindset — he tested structured vs. loose prompting and updated his approach based on output quality
- Strong self-awareness about personal failure conditions (unusual hours, incomplete internal monologue)
- Upstream investment discipline that reduces downstream verification and correction load
- Genuine workflow integration — AI is not occasional, it is structurally embedded in his writing process

Areas for Improvement

- Workflow is largely tacit and lives in his head — not documented, templated, or transferable
- No described QA mechanism beyond his own judgment and expertise; consistency across pieces relies on personal discipline rather than system design
- Acknowledged susceptibility to skipping upstream work when fatigued, with no structural safeguard against this
- The Socratic approach, while effective for him, depends heavily on his classical training — it is not a generalizable or teachable system as currently practiced

Knowledge Gaps

- No evidence of structured handoff, documentation, or reusable templates that would allow workflow repetition independent of his current mental state
- No described mechanism for quality consistency across pieces written under different conditions
- Unclear how he handles topics where his domain expertise is thinner — the workflow may be more brittle outside his deep knowledge areas

Section 6: Synthesis & Wrap-up

Summary

Michael used this conversation itself as a primary learning artifact — surfacing language for instincts he already had but couldn't articulate publicly. His recent "changes" are less about new techniques and more about conceptual clarification: the intellectual margin framing, the laziness/incomplete-input distinction, and the Socratic prompting shift. He learns through a combination of technical research (Anthropic papers, interpretability work) and classical reasoning frameworks (Aristotle), which he integrates rather than treats as separate. His in-the-moment self-correction is strong and well-practiced — he reads "fighting the AI" as a signal, and copy-paste behavior as a fatigue indicator. His most honest and specific gap: AI's tendency to blur the line between technical improvement and audience drift, pulling his voice toward AI register rather than his own. He acknowledged this as an unsolved calibration problem, not just a discipline issue.

Key Insights

- Michael treats structured reflection (like this assessment) as a legitimate learning mechanism —

- Michael tests structured reflection (and this assessment) as a legitimate learning mechanism; he extracts conceptual clarity from conversation, not just information
- His learning inputs are strong and distinctive (interpretability research + classical philosophy), but the feedback loop on actual AI outputs is more intuitive than systematic
- His sharpest self-identified gap — audience drift vs. technical improvement — is genuine and specific, not generic
- In-the-moment self-correction is well-developed; he has reliable behavioral signals (fighting the AI, copy-paste) that trigger recalibration
- Learning velocity is steady rather than rapid — he is deepening an existing framework rather than expanding into new territory

Strengths

- Strong self-awareness about what has changed and why, even when the change is conceptual rather than behavioral
- Honest identification of a real, specific gap (audience drift) rather than a safe or vague one
- Integrates diverse inputs (technical research, classical philosophy) into a coherent personal framework
- Reliable in-the-moment correction signals that he reads deliberately rather than reactively

Areas for Improvement

- Learning is primarily input-driven (reading, research) with limited evidence of structured output review or failure analysis
- Growth is largely within an established framework — limited signal of expanding into genuinely new territory or use cases
- The audience drift problem is identified but no solution or mitigation strategy was articulated

Knowledge Gaps

- No evidence of peer learning, collaborative feedback, or external benchmarking outside of moments like this assessment
- Unclear how he would systematically test for audience drift rather than catching it after the fact
- No mention of how he tracks or measures improvement over time beyond felt sense

🔗 Competitive Context

Advanced practitioner in the top quartile — sophisticated mental models, mature workflow instincts, and strong domain-anchored verification habits that outperform most professional users.

⚠️ The Brutal Truth

You are a sophisticated operator within your zone of philosophical and engineering expertise, and your prompting philosophy is coherent — but it doubles as cover for under-specified initial prompts. You name four missing elements (audience, hook, end goal, outline) only after being probed, then frame their absence as intentional. Sometimes it is; sometimes it's just front-loading you didn't do. Your verification works because you know Aquinas's voice — outside that domain, the same instincts won't fire, and you don't have a systematic backup. Your workflow lives in your head, which makes it brittle when you're tired. The audience drift problem is your sharpest self-diagnosis and you have no plan for it.

⚠️ Michael's Critical Bottleneck

The dominant constraint is the gap between tacit mastery and systematized practice. Your judgment is strong, your instincts are calibrated, and your mental models are sophisticated — but almost none of it is externalized into repeatable structure. This shows up in three interlocking ways: (1) initial prompts under-specify because the context lives in your head and you trust yourself to course-correct downstream, which costs iteration rounds; (2) verification depends on domain expertise rather than a portable framework, creating blind spots whenever you work outside philosophy or engineering; (3) your workflow has no QA mechanism beyond your own discipline, so quality degrades predictably at unusual hours or under fatigue. The audience drift problem is the clearest symptom: you can feel it happening but have no structural check. Systematizing what you already know would compound your existing strengths faster than learning new techniques.

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Michael, keep going

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